transmission. Could he be faking the messages to divert the SIT to different directions, so they always ended up drawing a blank? He shared his apprehensions with Raju and Kanth. They told him not to lose hope. Sivarasan had been ahead in the game so far but they had to beat him at his own game.

In another operation past midnight, the SIT rushed a sixty-man force led by Raju, Kanth, Verma and Ragothaman, along with a thirty-member squad of the NSG led by Ravindran, to Pulicat lake on the Tamil Nadu–Andhra Pradesh border. It was a massive operation following intercepted messages indicating that Sivarasan was camping out in a boat in the lake. The massive tracking team combed every inch of the 600-plus sq km lake in the dead of night only to find that they had been handed another red herring. Sivarasan had used that hideout only to transmit a message to attract the SIT's attention.

On the morning of 29 June, an interstate service bus coming from Thiruvanmiyur stopped at Royapettah in Madras and picked up a man who looked to be in his thirties and who carried a bag. He had a startling resemblance to Sivarasan. He got into the bus, kept his bag under the conductor's seat at the rear and moved up. Passengers rushed out of the bus fearing a blast. Some were heard shouting, 'Sivarasan! Sivarasan!' The passenger stood inside the bus for a while and then asked the driver why he would plant a bomb in a bus that he was travelling in himself.

There was no end to such stories. If a tip-off about Sivarasan's charred body being found in New Kalpakkam reached the SIT one day, the very next day he was spotted in Porur in Madras. It was true that Sivarasan had stayed in a house in Porur with Robert Payas, but the place had been raided much earlier, leaving no scope for Sivarasan to revisit that hideout. Then came the news of Sivarasan and Subha Sundaram being seen boarding an autorickshaw near the Vaigai river in Madurai. The local police had sealed off a large part of the city in search of the assassins. That tip-off, too, turned out to be false.

In a joint operation, the Indian navy and the Tamil Nadu Police launched a massive hunt for the fugitive on the Rameswaram coast following a tip-off